Gmail

Will Johnson <willyj1587@gmail.com>

# Tools for Life information request

3 messages

**McFeron, Hunter** <hunter.mcferon@gatfl.gatech.edu> Fri, Oct 10, 2025 at 9:03 AM
To: "willyj1587@gmail.com" <willyj1587@gmail.com>

Good morning William,

Thank you for reaching out to Tools for Life. We have received your request for information on AT devices and your interest in building your own. I'd be happy to provide some support. Is there a particular type of device you were interested in?

I will also include a brief description of our services below:

Tools for Life is the State of Georgia's Assistive Technology (AT) Act program. Our primary focus for AT support is providing group training/education, increasing AT awareness of potential AT tools and resources, AT device demonstrations, AT device loans, and providing information on potential sources of funding. We house an inventory of AT equipment and can loan AT devices to individuals and agencies for short-term trials of 4-6 weeks, as a "try-before-you-buy service." Our program does not conduct individual AT or AAC (Augmentative & Alternative Communication) assessments.

Best,
Hunter


**Hunter McFeron, MEd, CCC-SLP**
*Acquisition Services Manager* | Tools for Life

Center for Inclusive Design and Innovation

Center for Inclusive Design & Innovation | Services & Education
**Georgia** Institute of **Tech**nology | College of Design
512 Means Street | Suite 250 | Atlanta, GA 30318

cidi.gatech.edu | gatfl.gatech.edu


**Will Johnson** <willyj1587@gmail.com> Fri, Oct 10, 2025 at 9:55 AM
To: "McFeron, Hunter" <hunter.mcferon@gatfl.gatech.edu>

Good morning,

Thank you for the information on the Tools for Life services.

I am particularly interested in the intersection of Assistive Technology (AT) and my personal strengths in 3D printing, CAD, and electronics. My goal is to build my own AT solution to address my primary challenge, which is communication.

For context, I recently received a late diagnosis of Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD). My main difficulty is that my nonverbal communication and facial expressions often do not match my inner feelings and intentions. I am looking for a structured, custom tool to help me bridge this communication gap.

My Technical Approach and Strengths:

My expertise isn't just professional experience; it is rooted in a lifelong passion for how things work. I am a self-taught and highly tech-savvy individual with intense, preoccupying interests in 3D printing, CAD, woodworking, and electronics. Since childhood, I have always been more interested in taking things apart and building new things than in simply using objects as they are.

This drive to create custom solutions is why I am focused on DIY. I am currently teaching myself to code and am extremely interested in Artificial Intelligence (AI) and how it can be used to develop personalized, structured tools to assist with communication. My hope is to apply this high-level, technical skill set to my own challenges and, ultimately, to help others.

Since my interest is in building, could you please provide guidance on where I can find information regarding:

Open-Source Assistive Technology (AT) Projects: Resources, online communities, or directories that focus on DIY or customizable AT designs, particularly for Augmentative and Alternative Communication (AAC) or social/emotional support.

Funding or Grants for Building Materials: Information on potential sources of funding to purchase specialized components or materials for personal AT projects.

Local Makerspaces or Tech Communities in Georgia that specialize in AT fabrication or design.

Offer to Volunteer:

Separately, I would also like to offer my technical skills and resources to your organization. I have deep experience in 3D printing, CAD, and electronics and have a significant amount of filament. I would be happy to volunteer my time and skills if you have any need for:

3D printing components for your device loan inventory.

CAD design work for customized AT solutions.

Technical support for other AT projects.

I look forward to hearing about any volunteer opportunities you may have or any directions you can point me in regarding DIY resources.

Thank you for your guidance.

Sincerely,

Will Johnson

On Fri, Oct 10, 2025 at 9:03 AM McFeron, Hunter <hunter.mcferon@gatfl.gatech.edu> wrote:
>

> Good morning William,
>
> Thank you for reaching out to Tools for Life. We have received your request for information on AT devices and your interest in building your own. I'd be happy to provide some support. Is there a particular type of device you were interested in?
>
> I will also include a brief description of our services below:
>
> Tools for Life is the State of Georgia's Assistive Technology (AT) Act program. Our primary focus for AT support is providing group training/education, increasing AT awareness of potential AT tools and resources, AT device demonstrations, AT device loans, and providing information on potential sources of funding. We house an inventory of AT equipment and can loan AT devices to individuals and agencies for short-term trials of 4-6 weeks, as a "try-before-you-buy service." Our program does not conduct individual AT or AAC (Augmentative & Alternative Communication) assessments.
>
>
> Best,
> Hunter
>
>
> Hunter McFeron, MEd, CCC-SLP
>
> Acquisition Services Manager | Tools for Life
>
>
>
>
[Quoted text hidden]

---

**McFeron, Hunter** <hunter.mcferon@gatfl.gatech.edu> Wed, Oct 15, 2025 at 8:11 AM
To: Will Johnson <willyj1587@gmail.com>

Good morning Will,

I can provide you with a couple of suggestions!

Regarding open source AT projects, I would recommend checking out the website https://www.makersmakingchange.com/. Users frequently upload new 3D printing projects onto their site, and they can even connect you with folks out in the real world who are in need of some of the designs and products on their site. I believe they will also periodically post funding and grant opportunities related to 3D printing.

As for organizations that specialize in AT design and fabrication, it might be worth reaching out to Tikkum Olam Makers (TOM) Global. They have visited our program several times and have a student-run branch here on Georgia Tech's campus. I will include contact info for their global group and the Georgia Tech club below:

TOM Global
https://tomglobal.org/contact

TOM (Georgia Tech)
Georgiatech@tomglobal.org

Last, I will reach out to our director about your offer to volunteer. We are currently working to understand the volunteer process here at Georgia Tech, but I know we would love to have some support and knowledge on 3D printing!

Thanks,
Hunter

**Hunter McFeron, MEd, CCC-SLP**
*Acquisition Services Manager* | Tools for Life

Center for Inclusive Design and Innovation

Center for Inclusive Design & Innovation | Services & Education
**Georgia** Institute of **Tech**nology | College of Design
512 Means Street | Suite 250 | Atlanta, GA 30318

cidi.gatech.edu | gatfl.gatech.edu

---

**From:** Will Johnson <willyj1587@gmail.com>
**Sent:** Friday, October 10, 2025 9:55 AM
**To:** McFeron, Hunter <hunter.mcferon@gatfl.gatech.edu>
**Subject:** Re: Tools for Life information request

[Quoted text hidden]